

would be any of the following: computer science, information technology, computer engineering, electronics and telecommunications, electrical engineering, information technology and telecommunications.

These degrees can be procured from leading engineering colleges across India. The degree programs cover topics such as basics of computer networks, network management and security, working with various network protocols, operating systems, and other networking-related topics.

There are also short-term courses that focus on networking topics offered by some institutions as an alternative to a four-year degree program.

Continuous Learning

Learning in this field is unlimited. With rapidly-changing network technologies, networking professionals have to keep themselves constantly updated. "Networks today have become very complex, and learning is a continuous process. The challenging part of this field is to maintain a balance between individual learning interests and keeping track with technological advancements," says Tarun Hukku, Head - Resource Management Group of Microland, an IT infrastructure management and technical support services outsourcing company.

Short-term courses may help in quick acquisition of basic networking knowledge by more focused programs on networking topics. Degree programs, on the other hand, lay in-depth foundations and reflect a level of dedication to prospective employers.

Today, international-level certifications are available from various vendors such as Cisco, Microsoft, Red Hat, Juniper, and IBM. Also, the international-level certification of the CompTIA (Computing Technology Industry Association) is now possible to acquire by an examination: for more details, visit www.comptia.org/trainingandeducation. Pursuing training from the authorised training centres of the vendor companies and taking examinations, help in gaining knowledge, to be at par with the requirements of the industry. For further details on certification courses and the authorised training centres of international vendors, see box A *List Of Popular Certifications*.

Many branches of private institutes such as CMS Institute, Jetking, Aptech, Accel, and more, are spread all over India, which provide coaching and training on hardware and networking topics irrespective of the vendor platform.

At the time of recruiting freshers, employers look at what projects the applicant has under-



Global
certifications keep one above par, and those with one have a definite edge over the others"

Muthu Logan
Founder and CEO
BroVis Wireless
Networks Ltd

taken, and whether there is any relevant working experience. While recruiting network professionals through basic-level technical written tests, organisations check for the clarity of the fundamentals of the applicant.

Besides qualifications and certifications, soft skills such as good communication, presentation skills, self-confidence, application of logic, and leadership qualities are also examined by employers at the time of recruitment.

Certifications

Which certification is the best? The answer depends upon the individual's interest in a particular area of networking, and also the preferences of the hiring companies. Certification courses are designed for three levels—Beginner, Intermediate, and Expert or Advanced, and are awarded to accredit anyone who has proved eligible after passing the examinations. A few ambitious students acquire multiple certifications—sometimes more than four!

"Certification is a must nowadays. It provides in-depth knowledge of the technology along with practical exposure. Certifications really help when they are done along with the job in the same field, and you can link the knowledge to your day-to-day work," says Manish Macwan, now an Assistant IT Specialist (messaging and groupware), CMS Computers Ltd.

Passing the tests and getting a global certification naturally keeps you a notch above those who do not possess one. Along with the certification, some working experience in industry gives a complete picture of what organisations want, and how can one fulfil that by acquiring qualifications and certifications which the organisation basically look for in.

Also, pursuing certification in specialised areas such as network security, servers, systems, etc. depends upon an individual's personal interest. Besides this, the benefits one gets from global certifications are global acceptance, better monetary returns, greater confidence, and better growth opportunities.

The Career Growth Path

The networking segment is one of the fastest growing in the IT industry. Services such as broadband, VoIP, videoconferencing, and VPNs have spurred the need for networking professionals who can set up, manage, and provide solutions in these areas.

Getting hired successfully in a company doesn't mean an end to learning; it is an ongoing process. Companies organise or sponsor internal training and education of their employees in order to enhance their knowledge and bring out better solutions with their knowledge for the organisation. After entering the networking segment as a fresher, they can reach to the top designation passing the following positions.

Beginner level (approx. salary per annum: Rs 1.8 lakh to Rs 4 lakh)

End-User Support Specialist
Information Technology Technician
Help Desk / Customer Support

A List Of Popular Certifications

To know more about the entry level, professional, specialist, and expert-level certifications, courses, and their authorised training centres, visit the following sites.

Cisco: www.cisco.com/web/learning/
IBM: www-03.ibm.com/certify/

Juniper: www.juniper.com/training
Microsoft: www.microsoft.com/learning/default.msp
Novell: www.novell.com/training/
Nortel: www.nortel.com/training
Red Hat: www.redhat.com/training
Sun Microsystems: www.sun.com/training